

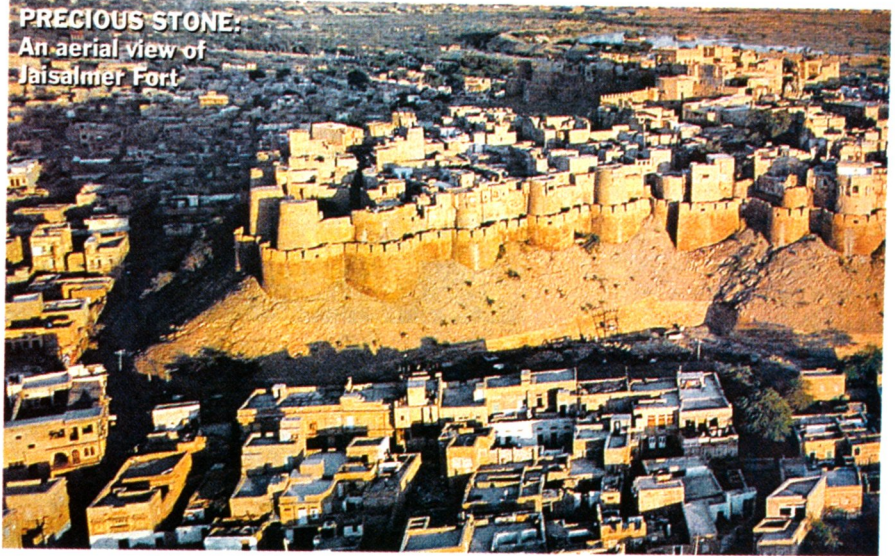
and his travels across India with a TV crew to meet marginalised people.

His mother is the unifying element in this book and is one of the reasons it is such a page-turner. This highly practical woman and her husband are beautifully portrayed as two outstanding examples of the plain people of India, full of a natural nobility, culture, compassion, tolerance and truth. Their love story, beginning in a wealthy Pathan household in Baluchistan before Partition, carries total conviction. And so does every word of this book. Mirza writes only of those things that he holds most dear and that he stands for.

He is passionately concerned about the millions of Indians he believes are being left out of India's newfound prosperity. In a post-9/11 world, he cares for all the victims of violence. Mirza captures the essence of Indian culture, which is his birth right, and makes it a point to include largely forgotten stories from the golden age of Islam. In the novel, his father, very much enamoured of machines and modernity, starts his career as a schoolteacher in Sibi, one of the hottest places in the world, just south of the Bolan Pass which leads up to Quetta. There he teaches his wife about the scholars and scientists of an age when Islamic civilisation honoured all knowledge, from Aryabhatta to Aristotle. One of his father's heroes from this period, Ibn Rushd, said that the best society was one where each woman, child and man had all the means to develop their God-given potential. This would be a society where no man acted out of fear of a prince or of hell, or out of desire for a reward from courtiers or of heaven, and where no one said, "This belongs to me".

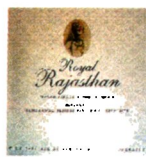
Mirza's parents were attracted by such idealism and had great faith in the power of Indian democracy in making the society better and more egalitarian. That faith was shaken by events at the end of their lives, but they, like most Indians, continued to stand by their own generous values. As we pass into another and so far brutal phase of world history, it is important to remember them, and all those like them. Their qualities need to be treasured and renewed in the generations to come and perhaps it is in this hope that Saeed Mirza has put heart and soul into this, his first book. ■

PRECIOUS STONE:
An aerial view of
Jaisalmer Fort



Desert Chic

Two new books on Rajasthan offer proof of why the state's rich and regal past continues to attract tourists, authors and photographers



ROYAL RAJASTHAN
by PRAMOD KAPUR, KISHORE SINGH
Roli Books
Price: Rs 2,975
Pages: 192



BEYOND THE DUNES
by JUHI SINHA
Penguin
Price: Rs 275
Pages: 235

■ By Dilip Bobb

India's erstwhile royals enacted their outrageous lives in every corner of the country. The gilded palaces and memorials to their existence are still found all over, from Hyderabad to Gwalior, Agra to Mysore. Yet, the only modern metaphor for Indian royalty is Rajasthan. The state has become a tourist Mecca riding on the caparisoned back of its regal past even though maharajas of other states were richer and led more colourful lives. There is reason for that. Being a warrior community, the Rajputs carved out a multitude of kingdoms and princely states, with the result that there is more royal history and architecture in Rajasthan than in the rest of India. Then there is the rugged desert backdrop, which adds to the ambience. Also, Rajasthan's royals have been fiercely protective about their customs, heritage and hierarchy, which makes their modern avatars as authentic as is possible. Finally, there is the colourful attire and macho image of the Rajput, which has

stayed intact. No wonder the state attracts an endless assembly line of books and pictorial tributes to its regal past.

We now have two additions to the list. One is a coffee table book on royal Rajasthan, the other a paperback on the author's journeys in the state while filming documentaries for television. So what do the two books add to the existing royal banquet? Juhi Sinha's Rajasthan is seen through the eyes of a TV producer and much of the book is about her personal experiences while filming. Part travelogue and part personal diary, it gives us nothing new on the state itself, apart from a few anecdotes and personal encounters with a variety of royals who run heritage hotels, where she stayed. There is more about her TV crews than Rajasthan's unique character. As a literary effort, it has a veneer of self-indulgence.

Royal Rajasthan is largely a picture book, with some rare archival and aerial photographs of the state's iconic forts and palaces. This book lends ample support to the adage that a picture equals a thousand words. ■